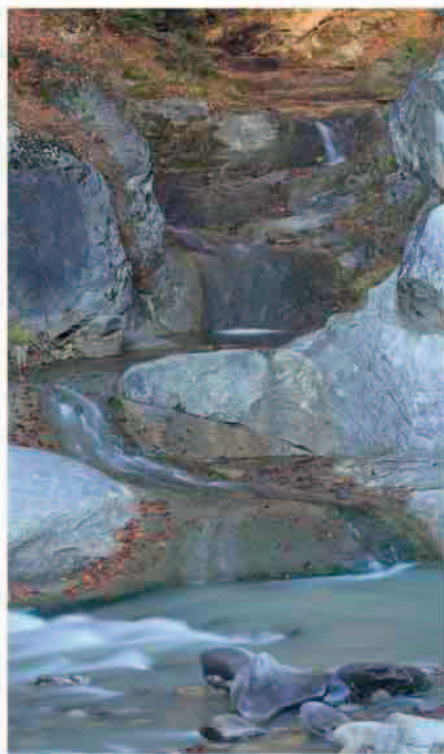


Rivers and valleys

As water drains off the land, it gradually carves away the uplands, cutting a network of stream and river valleys. The water carries eroded rock, sand, and silt from the uplands to the lowlands, depositing them as sediments. These sediments change the shape of the land and also contain the plant nutrients that make the lowlands so fertile.

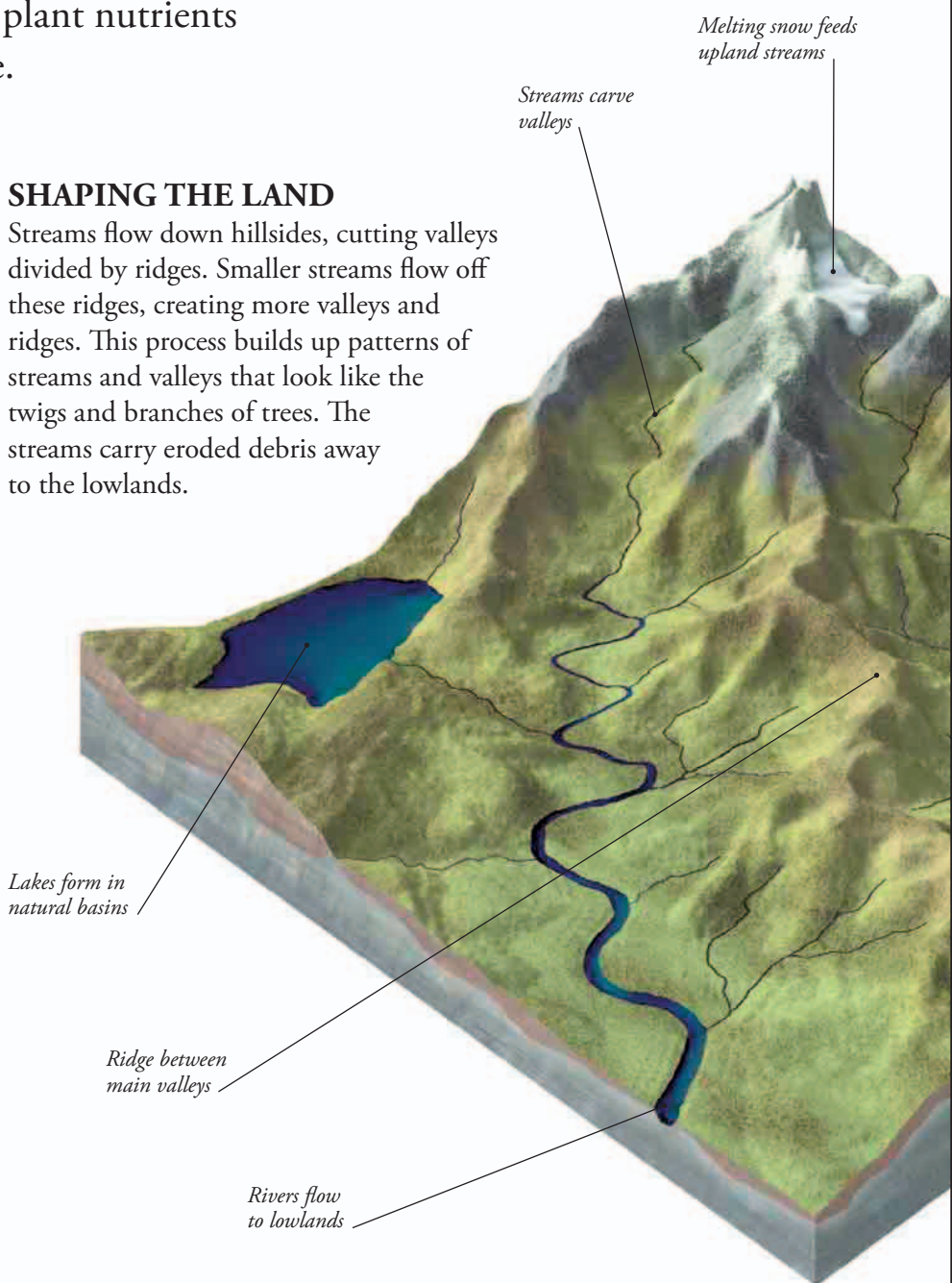
SPRINGS AND STREAMS

Rainwater drains downhill over hard rock in trickles and rivulets. It also soaks into the ground and seeps through the rock until it emerges at springs. Rivulets and springwater flow together into streams, and these join with other streams to form rivers.



SHAPING THE LAND

Streams flow down hillsides, cutting valleys divided by ridges. Smaller streams flow off these ridges, creating more valleys and ridges. This process builds up patterns of streams and valleys that look like the twigs and branches of trees. The streams carry eroded debris away to the lowlands.



FAST FACTS

- The largest river in the world by volume is the Amazon in South America. It empties 52 million gallons (200,000 cubic meters) of water into the Atlantic Ocean every second.
- The Nile Delta spreads out across 150 miles (240 km) of the Egyptian coast on the Mediterranean Sea.
- The Gandaki River in Nepal cuts a gorge through the Himalayan mountains that is 18,000 ft (5,500 m) deeper than the peaks on either side of it.